



TRAFFIC on Interstate 80 near Truckee during heavy snow on Friday. A weekend storm dropped 2 feet of fresh powder in Lake Tahoe.

California’s wild weather shows divide between north and south

It’s only mid-December, yet dramatic swings in weather already appear to be marking California’s transition toward winter — and the volatility probably is far from over.

Just this past week, a major wildfire raced into Malibu, fueled by dangerous Santa Ana winds, and a powerful storm dumped feet of snow in the mountains, caused flooding in the Bay Area and formed a tornado in Santa Cruz County.

And now, forecasters warn that similar conditions are likely to return this week, with high winds in Southern California prompting further fire concerns and a series of atmospheric rivers bound for

High winds and fire danger contrast with more heavy rain and potential flooding

By Grace Toohey

Northern California that could bring more flooding and headaches for travelers.

These diverging weather patterns are providing the latest reminder about how much California can differ climatologically, especially when it comes to early-winter precipitation.

“It’s fairly common to have other parts of the West get targeted and we kind of get left out,” Robbie Munroe, a National Weather Service meteorologist in Oxnard, said of Southern California’s dryness relative to up north. He said the sharp contrast often eases by January or February, when the jet stream —

[See **Weather**, A5]

Justices nix states’ challenge against California

Court dismisses air pollution appeal after agreeing to consider oil producers’ case.

By David G. Savage

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court on Monday dismissed a red-state constitutional challenge to California’s special authority to fight air pollution.

Over a dissent by Justice Clarence Thomas, the court turned away an appeal from Ohio and 16 other conservative states, which asked the court to rule “the Golden State is not a golden child.”

Although Monday’s brief order closes the door on a constitutional challenge to California’s antipollution standards, the court on Friday cleared the way for a different, more targeted legal challenge.

The oil and gas industry is suing over the state’s “zero emissions” goals for new vehicles, arguing California’s special authority to fight air pollution does not extend to greenhouse gases and global warming.

The D.C. Circuit Court in Washington dismissed that suit in April on the grounds that the oil producers had no standing to sue. Their com-

[See **High court**, A5]

Untangling the complex online ideology of Luigi Mangione

When Luigi Mangione was arrested in the killing of the chief executive of UnitedHealthcare, he was hailed in many corners of the internet as an anti-capitalist folk hero.

In a document said to be a “manifesto” found with Mangione, published online by journalist Ken Klippenstein, the 26-year-old former data engineer condemned UnitedHealthcare for abusing “our country for immense profit.”

“Frankly, these parasites simply had it coming,” Mangione wrote. “A reminder: the US has the #1 most expensive healthcare system in the world, yet we rank roughly #42 in life expectancy.”

But Mangione was not a straightforward, left-leaning Robin Hood figure avenging what he sees as the brutality of the U.S. healthcare system or, as one right-wing critic alleged, “just another leftist nut job.” The political ideology he articulated online — on social media platforms from X and Reddit to Goodreads — defied neat left-right binaries and showed a young man steeped in a hodgepodge of online Silicon Valley philosophy and heterodox ideas.

The suspect in a healthcare CEO’s shooting death has politics that defy neat left-right categorization

By Summer Lin and Jenny Jarvie



BENJAMIN B. BRAUN Pittsburgh Post-Gazette

MANGIONE, 26, a former data engineer, had shared posts online from an eclectic stream of thinkers.

Mangione’s internet postings, along with accounts from people he knew and talked to online, offer a complex view. Mangione’s last post on X was in June, nearly six months before he allegedly traveled to Manhattan to kill, and he appeared to disconnect from his family and friends around the same time. But his digital footprint offers a glimpse into his ideological journey, documenting some of his deepest hopes and anxieties about the future of technology and humanity.

The former valedictorian of an elite Baltimore prep school and Ivy League graduate shared posts on social media from an eclectic stream of populists, entrepreneurs, neuroscientists, centrists and disruptors. On X, he followed comedian and podcaster Joe Rogan; President-elect Donald Trump’s nominee for Health secretary, Robert F. Kennedy Jr.; liberal columnist Ezra Klein; and democratic socialist Rep. Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez of New York.

On a now-private Goodreads account that authorities reportedly identified as belonging to Mangione, he included a biography of tech

[See **Mangione**, A7]

Foreign students face a holiday dilemma

Several colleges, including USC, advise skipping trips home or returning before Trump’s inauguration.

By Jaweed Kaleem

As an international student at USC who had not been home for a year, Kevin Lu was excited to return over winter break to see his parents in the Chinese city of Shenzhen.

But with President-elect Donald Trump’s Jan. 20 inauguration approaching, he changed his mind, choosing to remain in Los Angeles.

“It’s too risky,” said Lu, a senior majoring in finance. Lu cited Trump’s hawkish stance on China, restrictions during his first term on Chinese student visas for scholars because they were a security “threat” and promises to sign another travel ban like the one nearly eight years ago that left many visa-holding students stranded at airports.

“You don’t know what’s next,” Lu said.

At USC, where more than a quarter of its 47,000 students are internationals, many are scrambling — with some changing their travel plans at the last minute and others rethinking post-graduation work searches in the U.S. — ahead of an incoming administration that has sent mixed signals on its interest in foreign students and workers.

The university is encouraging foreigners to take a tack similar to Lu’s and skip or cut short travel outside the U.S. after finals end this week.

USC is not alone in issuing such an advisory. UCLA and UC Berkeley also sent notices. Berkeley’s International Office told students that Trump’s first term “negatively impacted international students, scholars, and employees” and that “we can expect this pattern to continue.”

The University of Massachusetts Amherst’s Office of Global Affairs said that, “out of an abundance of caution,” international students should return to the country before the inauguration — as did MIT and Wesleyan University in similar messages.

The USC letter from the Office of International Services said the new administration “may issue one or more executive orders impacting travel to the U.S. and visa processing. While there’s no certainty such orders will be issued, the safest way to avoid any challenges is to be physically present in the U.S. before the spring semester begins on January 13.

[See **Students**, A5]

Trump speaks at news conference

The president-elect takes media questions for the first time since the election. **NATION**, A4

Wisconsin school shooter kills 2

A 17-year-old girl opened fire before taking her own life, police say. **NATION**, A4

Breaking a tie in council election

In a small town, a drawing decides which of two candidates is the winner. **CALIFORNIA**, B1

New rules for home insurance

What homeowners should know about “catastrophe models” and rates. **BUSINESS**, A6

Weather

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